

The National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of

2013-04-23 • UHG • Nationale Geistige Räte

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2013-04-23

295

52

23 April 2013

The National Spiritual Assembly

of the Bahá'ís of Denmark

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

52.1 . . . The challenge you face in helping the friends in your

community to understand the Bahá'í teachings and to apply

them in their lives, as the forces of materialism continue to

grow in strength, is appreciated by the Universal House of

Justice. Enclosed for your reference is a letter recently written

on its behalf to three believers in a neighboring country who shared similar concerns about the struggles experienced by

young Bahá'í men and women in their efforts to uphold the

standards of the Faith, particularly those related to chastity and marriage. It is hoped that the points set out in the letter

will assist you in your deliberations on the subject. As the letter

makes clear, the issues involved can best be considered in light

of the relationships that the Administrative Order seeks to forge

among the individual, the institutions, and the community. While responsibility for adhering to the Bahá'í standard rests

primarily on the individual believer, it is incumbent upon the in-

stitutions of the Faith to support the individual, largely through educational endeavors, and to foster a pattern of community

life that is conducive to the spiritual upliftment of its members.

It is understood, of course, that in the assumption of these and

other sacred duties, Bahá'í institutions may find it necessary

at times to take specific action as a means of protecting the community and the integrity of Bahá'í law.

52.2 In discharging their educational responsibilities towards the body of the believers, the institutions of the Faith need to bear in mind how little is accomplished when their efforts are reduced to repeated admonitions or to dogmatic instruction in proper conduct. Rather should their aim be to raise consciousness and to increase understanding. Theirs is not the duty to pry
296

FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION into personal lives or to impose Bahá'í law on the individual but to create an environment in which the friends eagerly arise to fulfill their obligations as followers of Bahá'u'lláh, to uphold His law, and to align their lives with His teachings. The efforts of the institutions will bear fruit to the extent that the friends, especially those of the younger generation, find themselves immersed in the activities of a vibrant and growing community and feel confirmed in the mission with which Bahá'u'lláh has entrusted them.

52.3 One of the most effective instruments at your disposal in this respect is the training institute. It strives to engage the individual in an educational process in which virtuous conduct and self-discipline are developed in the context of service, fostering a coherent and joyful pattern of life that weaves together

study, worship, teaching, community building and, in general, involvement in other processes that seek to transform society.

At the heart of the educational process is contact with the

Word of God, whose power sustains every individual's attempts to purify his or her heart and to walk a path of service with

“the feet of detachment.” The Guardian encouraged young

believers to learn through “active, wholehearted and continued participation” in community activities. Addressed to one

young believer, a letter written on his behalf explained: “Bahá'í community life provides you with an indispensable laboratory,

where you can translate into living and constructive action the

principles which you imbibe from the Teachings.” “By becoming a real part of that living organism,” the letter went on, “you

can catch the real spirit which runs throughout the Bahá'í

Teachings.” Such wholehearted participation in the work of

the Faith provides an invaluable context for the exertion made

by young and old alike to align their lives with Bahá'u'lláh's teachings. This is not to say that individuals will not err from

time to time, perhaps on occasion in serious ways. Yet, when

the desire to uphold the Bahá'í standard is nurtured through

service to the common weal in an environment of unfailing

love and warm encouragement, the friends will not feel, in the face of such difficulty, that they have no other recourse but to

withdraw from community activity out of a sense of shame or,

worse, to cover the challenges they are experiencing with the veneer of propriety, living a life in which public words do not

conform to private deeds.

297

addressed in concert with efforts to enhance the capacities

of the community and its institutions. The enclosed letter

describes some of the characteristics of the community life that

Bahá'ís, guided by the institutions, are striving to create. The

environment sought is, at the most fundamental level, one of love and support, in which the believers, all endeavoring to achieve the Bahá'í standard in their personal conduct, show

patience and respect to each other and, when needed, receive

wise counsel and ready assistance. Gossip and backbiting have

no place in the Bahá'í community; nor do judgmental attitudes

and self-righteousness.

52.5 What is essential for every National Assembly to acknowl-

edge in this connection is that, if mutual love and support

within the community, important as it is, becomes the only

focus, a stagnant environment engendered by an insular men-

talidity will develop. The worldwide Bahá'í community is charged

with an historic mission. It must acquire capacity to address increasingly complex spiritual and material requirements as

it becomes larger and larger in size. The 28 December 2010

message of the House of Justice indicated: “A small community, whose members are united by their shared beliefs, character -

ized by their high ideals, proficient in managing their affairs and tending to their needs, and perhaps engaged in several

humanitarian projects—a community such as this, prospering

but at a comfortable distance from the reality experienced by the masses of humanity, can never hope to serve as a pattern for

restructuring the whole of society.” The current series of global

Plans sets out provisions for gradually building individual and collective capacity for the community's mission. The institu-

tions of a Bahá'í community that has been allowed to become

complacent will find it difficult to protect the younger members

from the forces of gross materialism, with the accompanying

moral decay, that are assailing society. This, then, points to the nature of the capacity-building process in which every Bahá'í

institution must energetically engage.

52.6 Apart from the measures noted above, which serve to rein-

force the integrity of the Bahá'í community, there may be times when specific action is required on the part of the institutions

to protect it and to uphold the law. Intervention in any specific

case needs, of course, to be carried out with the utmost delicacy

and wisdom. Such cases present themselves when the breach of

298

FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONBahá'í law is public and flagrant, potentially bringing the Faith

into disrepute and damaging its good name, or when the indi-

vidual demonstrates a callous disregard for the teachings and

the institutions of the Faith, with harmful consequences for the

functioning of the Bahá'í community. In these circumstances,

Spiritual Assemblies should follow a middle way: They should not adopt a passive approach, which would be tantamount to

condoning behavior contrary to the teachings and which would

undermine the imperative to obey Bahá'í law in the eyes of the members of the community. Neither, however, should they act

rashly or rigidly to enforce the law, imposing administrative sanctions arbitrarily.

52.7 Should the conduct of a believer become so blatant as

to attract the attention of the Assembly, it would want, after

gaining a relatively clear picture of the issues, to offer loving

but firm advice to the friend involved. In most cases it is

necessary, in the first instance, to determine to what extent the

believer understands the Faith and its standards. Dispassionate counseling, not infrequently over an extended period, to

assist the individual concerned in gaining an appreciation of

the requirements of Bahá'í law is generally required. So, too, is patience needed, and he or she should be given sufficient

time to bring about a change. The Assembly, often aided by

the Counsellors or the members of the Auxiliary Boards, may

have to help the individual reflect on his or her particular

circumstances, apply relevant principles, and explore available options. In deciding on what approach to take, the Assembly

should be guided by the understanding that its objective is to

assist the friends to draw closer to the Faith while taking care to protect the Bahá'í community from the negative influence

of those who have no intention of adhering to its standards.

When a believer demonstrates an allegiance to the Cause and

a willingness to rectify the situation, continued patience and

loving guidance are in order. All throughout, of course, care is taken to ensure that an individual's struggles do not become a

source of backbiting or disunity in the community. In this the

members of the community need to remember that they should

each focus their energies on their own spiritual development

and on overcoming their personal shortcomings.

52.8 Only in circumstances where a believer, ignoring all

admonishments, persists in misconduct and knowingly and

consistently violates the law, would it be necessary for the

299

after warning the individual of the consequences of his or her

continued disregard for the teachings. The decision in such

matters is left to the National Spiritual Assembly, which is

to proceed with the utmost care and circumspection. What is

at stake is the participation of the individual in those aspects of community life internal to the body of the followers of

Bahá'u'lláh's teachings, not his or her civil rights. In some cases,

partial sanctions may be adequate, allowing the Assembly to deal with a situation in a flexible manner. For example, if the

hope is to reawaken in the individual a desire to participate in

community life, full sanctions may be counterproductive; an

appropriate partial sanction, such as suspending his or her right

to be elected to an Assembly, may prove sufficient, for, in any event, it would not be reasonable for a person who flagrantly

violates Bahá'í law to be in a position to govern the affairs

of the community. Restricting the believer from other forms of service—for instance, acting as a tutor of a study circle or

as a children's class teacher—may also be considered. Full re-

moval of administrative rights should be reserved for the most

severe and intractable cases, especially when the protection

of the community becomes a concern. The wise use of partial sanctions thus provides the Assembly with another means of

strengthening the individual and the community. In letters

written on behalf of the Guardian advising Assemblies on such

matters, he explained that, "although it is sometimes necessary

to take away the voting rights of a believer for purposes of discipline," this prerogative of the National Assembly "should

be used only in extreme cases." If heavy sanctions are applied

to certain acts of immorality, he also observed, "it is only fair to impose equally heavy sanctions on any Bahá'ís who step

beyond the moral limits defined by Bahá'u'lláh," which would

obviously, given the circumstances of humanity today, "create

an impossible and ridiculous situation.”

52.9 One final point deserves mention: There may be times when

an individual who shows complete indifference to the counsels of the institutions and firm resolution in his or her desire to

maintain the status quo has no apparent interest in engaging in

the life of the Bahá'í community. In such a case, provided that

his or her conduct has no significant bearing on the good name

of the Faith, the Assembly may decide to leave the individual to

go his or her own way, neither insisting on continued contact

300

FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONnor feeling obliged to impose sanctions. Equally, however, the

Assembly need not be anxious about quickly removing the

name of the individual from its rolls, given that circumstances

change and a person may, over time, decide to mend his or her

ways and return to participate in the life of the community.

52.10 In considering matters such as those outlined above, both

in handling particular cases and in addressing the broader

question of cultivating an attitude of love and respect towards

Bahá'í laws and standards, you will no doubt find ongoing con-

sultation with the Counsellors both essential and illuminating.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]